‘Oh, nothing, I was just wondering if the number is good it might offset the bad things that your cell number eight brings.’

Chandra immediately ran to his cell and started counting. When he came back pale, we kept discussing the weather, each one trying hard to suppress a laugh. These were some harmless fun we had at the expense of Chandra, but I had felt bad about the man who, like me, was jailed for no fault of his.

My first impression of Chandrasekhar, the Glavkosmos representative, was not very pleasant. It was during the cryogenic deliberations with the Russians that Chandrasekhar first became close to me. While on a flight to Moscow, he was accompanying us to a meeting with the Russian space agency.

I was quietly sipping on my whiskey when he came to me and started small talk. I politely asked him to leave me alone, but the Glavkosmos agent was too keen to entertain me with his antics.

‘I can give you company for a drink or two,’ he said.

‘Can you get lost?’ I retorted.

Later, he was made to stand outside the meeting hall as we discussed details of the cryogenic contract with the Glavkosmos higher-ups. Chandrasekhar did not nurse a grudge. Here now, seeing him getting paranoid about the number of iron bars on his cell gate, I felt pity for the man who was used to having four drinks a day, not more than one each at a five-star hotel in Bangalore where he lived.

My thoughts were often broken by noise made by Ripper. He was occasionally taken along the corridor, his legs chained. He would stop by my cell, mostly to foul-mouth policemen.

‘These buggers think they can keep me in these chains,’ he said one day, pointing to the metal shackles across his ankles. ‘I have broken many jails and these guys know I can do it again. I am just being nice to them.’

This man had an inherent hate for the khaki-clad.

Ripper told me that he was getting daily updates about the ISRO spy case, and that he knew we were innocent. I doubted if he followed the case; he would have been speaking out of his hatred for the system.